

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

PRE-RETURN NIGERIA

D9.1 - JANUARY 2026

Rodrigo Bolaños Suárez (bicc)
Zeynep Sahin-Mencutek (bicc)
Soner Barthoma (Uppsala University)



Funded by
the European Union

Name of practice	Shelter and Preparation for Return Information Campaigns on Assisted Voluntary Return	
Dates	2010 - present	
Target group	Returnees (inside and outside Nigeria)	
Geographic Scope	Country	Nigeria
	Regions	Africa
	Sub Region	West Africa
Actor	Patriotic Citizen Initiatives	
Return Stages	Pre-Return	
Challenge addressed	Logistics, Places, and Materiality. Governance, Cooperation and Coordination Voluntariness and Coercion	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Human-rights–based approach Vulnerability & Child-centred perspective Migrants’ Agency	

SUMMARY

The Patriotic Citizen Initiatives (PCI) has provided assistance to migrants who have been rescued from prisons in Libya, as well as those mistakenly identified as Nigerians when they are actually from countries like Sierra Leone, Mali, and Senegal. In partnership with the International Organisation for Migration (IOM), PCI offers temporary shelter for up to three months while the migrants' documentation and return arrangements are processed. Additionally, PCI has hosted Congolese nationals who were trafficked into Nigeria, helping them prepare for a safe and dignified return to the Democratic Republic of Congo.

PCI also serves as a local partner of the European Reintegration Support Organisation (ERSO). Their representatives travel to the Netherlands to reach out to irregular migrants—including those in deportation camps—informing them about the benefits of Assisted Voluntary Return (AVR). They also participate in high-level European engagement to promote dignified, informed, and sustainable return and reintegration for Nigerian migrants. By filling the information gap, PCI helps migrants make informed choices about AVR as an alternative to forced return. Beyond receiving them, PCI arranged temporary accommodation, retrieved belongings sent from Europe, and supported returnees in mapping out the gradual disbursement of reintegration assistance.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

PCI supports the dignified return and reintegration of migrants, assisting Nigerians from Europe and Libya as well as non-Nigerians who were misidentified or trafficked. In partnership with IOM, it provides temporary shelter and documentation support, while with ERSO it informs irregular migrants about Assisted Voluntary Return. Through EU engagement, PCI fosters collaboration and best practices, and also helps returnees with accommodation, belongings, and reintegration planning, bridging pre- and post-return stages. Despite these efforts, its reach is limited, shelter is short-term, documentation is slow, geographic scope is narrow, and sustainability is uncertain due to reliance on donor funding.

KEY LESSONS

PCI's experience shows that reintegration must be holistic, combining shelter, documentation, counselling, and financial support to ensure dignity and continuity.

Partnerships with IOM, ERSO and EU engagement extend its reach, while information on AVR empowers migrants to make informed choices. Its adaptability in assisting non-Nigerians is notable, but challenges remain—limited scale, donor dependence, short-term shelter, bureaucratic delays, and narrow geographic focus. Overall, PCI

highlights the need for comprehensive, collaborative, and sustainable reintegration approaches.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Initiatives and NGOs like PCI should expand their operations with sustainable funding and stronger institutional capacity to reduce reliance on partners. Shelter should extend beyond three months, with added psychosocial, vocational, and livelihood support, while streamlined documentation with agencies like NAPTIP, NIMC, and NCFRMI would ease delays.

Geographic coverage must go beyond Nigeria, the Netherlands, and Denmark, and advocacy on AVR should be strengthened. Deeper EU engagement can foster collaboration and best practices, while robust monitoring and evaluation will improve design, demonstrate impact, and enhance credibility.

REFERENCES

Uzomah, N. L., Madu, I. A., Ajaero, C. K., & Ezea, E. J. (2024). Navigating the Complexities of Return Migration and Reintegration: Challenges and Opportunities for Nigerian Migrants from North Africa in the Context of EU Policies (v.1). GAPs. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.14238373>

Okoye, P. (2025, December 16). Nigeria's revised migration policy: What has changed, and why it matters. Newspot Nigeria. <https://tribuneonline.ng.com/world-migrants-day-ngo-urges-nigerians-to-embrace-safe-regular-migration/>

PCI. (2025, April 17). PCI's director partnership visit to Europe on achieving sustainable reintegration for return migrants. Patriotic Citizen Initiatives. <https://www.pcinigeria.org/post/pci-s-director-partnership-visit-to-europe-on-achieving-sustainable-reintegration-for-return-migrant>